Canada Residency Pathway Guide

A practical guide for International Medical Graduates (IMGs)

BEYOND MEDICAL SCHOOL

Exposure • Mentorship • Opportunity

The 3 Broad IMG Pathways

Choose the pathway that matches your current level of training.

01 CaRMS — Canadian Residency

For IMGs who need to complete postgraduate residency training in Canada.

Think:

TRAIN IN CANADA

Typical route: medical degree → exams → CaRMS → residency.

02 Practice Ready Assessment (PRA)

For eligible internationally trained physicians who already have substantial independent clinical experience.

Think:

DEMONSTRATE READINESS

Usually province- and specialty-specific; requirements vary.

03 Specialist / Credential Recognition

For physicians who have already completed postgraduate specialist training.

Think:

HAVE SPECIALIST TRAINING RECOGNIZED

Routes may involve specialty-specific assessment and recognition.

Which Route Is Most Relevant to You?

A quick decision framework for BMS learners.

Medical degree + housemanship

No completed specialist training → CaRMS is usually the key residency route.

Experienced independent physician

You may be eligible for a Practice Ready Assessment, depending on province, specialty and experience.

Completed specialist training abroad

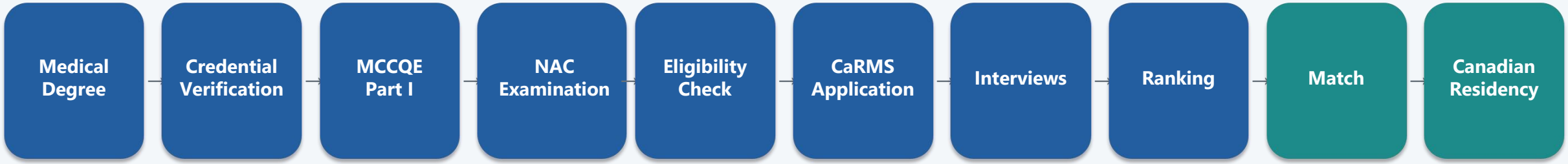
Explore specialist recognition / credential-assessment pathways, appropriate to your specialty.

Important

There is no single Canadian IMG pathway. **Province + specialty + training history matter.**

CaRMS: The Canadian Residency Route

The main pathway when your goal is to complete residency training in Canada.



Core idea: pass the required assessments → meet program eligibility → compete for a residency position.

Step 1–2: Medical Degree + Eligibility Check

1. Complete Your Primary Medical Qualification

Complete your Primary Medical Qualification (PMQ) and Get your MBCHB Certificate

2. Check Medical School Eligibility

-Confirm that your medical school meets the requirements for the Canadian pathway.

-Your medical school should be listed in the World Directory of Medical Schools (WDOMS) and meet the applicable Canadian recognition requirements.

-However, being listed in WDOMS does not by itself guarantee eligibility for every Canadian residency program. Provincial and program-specific criteria must also be checked.

Step 3–4: physiciansapply.ca + Identity

Create a physiciansapply.ca Account

Used for MCC services such as:

Medical credential verification

MCCQE Part I application

NAC Examination application

Accessing / sharing MCC examination information

Note: MCC fees are periodically updated. Applicants should always check the current MCC fee schedule before making payments

Establish Your Identity

Before proceeding with certain MCC services, you need to establish your identity. Requirements:

- An acceptable primary identity document, such as a passport
- Photograph
- Signature

The identity document must meet MCC's certification requirements. Acceptable certifying officials can include appropriately authorized officials such as a notary public or lawyer, subject to MCC requirements.

Step 5: Source Verification of Your Medical Credential

The goal is to confirm that your medical credential was genuinely issued by the institution named on it.

YOU
Upload credential

→

MCC
Reviews submission

→

EICS
Contacts issuing institution

→

MEDICAL SCHOOL
Verifies credential

→

MCC
Updates status

What should you verify?

For the standard CaRMS route, **the primary medical degree** is the key credential. Additional postgraduate/specialist credentials may matter for other pathways.

Current MCC source-verification fee: CAD $232* per medical credential

***Fee is subject to change**

Step 6: MCCQE Part I

A national examination assessing medical knowledge and clinical decision-making relevant to medical practice in Canada.

Current Format

- 230 MCQs
- 2 sections × 115 questions
- 2 hours 40 minutes per section
- Score: 300–600
- Current pass score: 439

Note: The current exam no longer contains the previous separate Clinical Decision-Making (CDM) component.

Exam is offered 4 times a year

Preparation

- Start with the MCC Examination Objectives + MCC Blueprint.
- Use Canadian-focused resources such as Toronto Notes and Canada-specific question banks like Canada Qbank and ACE Qbank
- UWorld can help with knowledge and clinical reasoning, but it should not replace MCC-specific preparation.

BMS tip: program requirements and selection practices vary, so img applicants should aim to perform as strongly as possible rather than simply target the pass mark.

Current Fee is CAD $1,500*

***Fee is Subject to change**

Step 7: NAC Examination / NAC OSCE

A clinical skills assessment used in the IMG residency pathway.

12 Stations

- 10 scored stations
- 2 pilot stations
- Pilot stations do not contribute to the final score.

Assessed Skills

- History taking
- Physical examination
- Diagnosis
- Management
- Communication
- Investigations
- Data interpretation

Score + Validity

- Score: 500–700
- Official pass score: 577
- Result does not expire.
- If taken more than once, the **most recent result** is the valid result.
- **BMS tip:** There is no universal 'competitive cutoff'. However, residency positions are competitive so applicants should aim for a strong score rather than simply the minimum passing score.

Step 8: Check Provincial + Program Eligibility

This is one of the most important steps—and one of the easiest to overlook.

What to Check

- Canadian citizenship / permanent residency requirements where applicable
- MCCQE Part I + NAC requirements
- Medical school eligibility
- Graduation-year / recency requirements
- Postgraduate training requirements
- Language requirements
- Provincial assessment requirements
- Return-of-service obligations
- Program-specific criteria

Golden Rule

Eligibility ≠ Match.

Being eligible for the CaRMS Match does not mean you qualify for every IMG program.

Criteria can change between match cycles.

Always check:

CaRMS provincial criteria + individual program requirements.

Immigration Status: Keep It Separate From Residency Eligibility

Why It Matters

- Many IMG residency positions have citizenship / permanent-residency requirements.
- Immigration pathways such as Express Entry and Provincial Nominee Programs are separate systemsfrom CaRMS.
- Do not assume that an immigration priority category automatically creates residency eligibility.

BMS Tip: It is important to work on Permanent residency as you are going through the pathway. Currently, Canada is looking for more doctors and have made getting a Permanent Residency relatively easier through Express Entry pathway and Provincial Nomination

BMS Advice

If Canada is your long-term goal, review your immigration strategy alongside your medical pathway.

Because immigration and CaRMS rules change, use current official sources before making major decisions.

Key message:

PR can be important—but **PR does not guarantee a residency match**.

Step 9: Build Your CaRMS Application

Once you know which programs you are eligible for, build a targeted application.

Typical Application Components

CV / application information

Medical school transcript

Medical diploma

MSPR / Dean's Letter where required

MCCQE Part I result

NAC result

Reference letters

Personal statements / letters where required

Other program-specific documents

How Programs Evaluate You

Academic record

Clinical experience

Exam performance

References

Personal letters

Research / teaching / leadership

Interview performance

Fit with program-specific criteria

CaRMS Application Costs — 2027 R-1 Match

Fees are cycle-specific; always verify the current CaRMS fee schedule.

Match participation fee	**CAD $301.60**	Includes first 4 programs
Additional program	**CAD $66.26 each**	For programs over the first 4
IMG verification fee	**CAD $136.62**	CaRMS verification fee

CaRMS states there is no minimum or maximum number of programs an applicant can apply to.

Step 10: Interviews

Getting an interview is a major milestone—but the match is still determined later.

Common Interview Areas

Tell us about yourself

Why Canada?

Why this specialty?

Why this program?

Previous clinical experience

Clinical scenarios

Ethics + professionalism

Communication + conflict resolution

Canadian healthcare system

BMS Preparation Strategy

Know your CV thoroughly.

Prepare concise, authentic answers.

Practise clinical and ethical scenarios.

Show reflection—not memorized answers.

Demonstrate teamwork, teachability and professionalism.

Remember:

Programs decide whom to interview.

Step 11: Ranking

After interviews, applicants and programs submit rank-order lists.

Applicant Rank Order List

- You rank programs in the order you genuinely prefer them.
- Rank only programs you would actually accept.
- Do not rank a program simply because you think it is 'easier'.

Program Rank Order List

Programs independently rank the applicants they interviewed.

The CaRMS matching algorithm considers both sides' preferences and available positions.

APPLICANT PREFERENCES ↔ PROGRAM PREFERENCES → MATCHING ALGORITHM

Step 12: Match Day 🎯

The moment the algorithm turns the ranking process into residency placements.

BEFORE MATCH DAY

Rank-order lists are finalized → CaRMS runs the matching algorithm

ON MATCH DAY

Log into CaRMS Online → MY RESULTS → Match Results

🎉MATCHED

You receive a residency position.

Follow the program's onboarding and registration instructions.

NOT MATCHED

Eligible applicants may proceed to the **second iteration**.

A post-match process may follow for positions that remain.

The exact Match Day dates change each cycle—check CaRMS for the current calendar.

Important BMS Notes for IMGs

Do Not Assume...

Passing MCCQE Part I = guaranteed residency

Passing NAC = guaranteed interview

WDOMS listing = eligibility for every program

PR = guaranteed CaRMS eligibility or match

One province's criteria = another province's criteria

Today’s requirements = next cycle’s requirements

Do This Instead

Check official CaRMS criteria every cycle.

Check individual program requirements.

Keep your MCC profile and documents updated.

Plan immigration separately but alongside your medical pathway.

Budget for exams, applications, travel and living costs.

Build a strong application—not just passing scores.

Your pathway may take several years. Plan exams, documents, immigration and finances early.

Beyond CaRMS: The Other Two IMG Routes

Practice Ready Assessment (PRA)

- Designed for eligible internationally trained physicians with substantial clinical experience.
- Often focused on family medicine / general practice, but province-specific opportunities vary.
- Assessment determines whether the physician is ready for independent practice in the relevant setting.
- Requirements, specialties, supervision and return-of-service conditions vary by province.

Specialist / Credential Recognition

- For physicians who have completed postgraduate specialist training abroad.
- Assessment is specialty-specific.
- Possible routes include Royal College assessment pathways and other approved processes.
- Recognition is not automatic—training and credentials are assessed against Canadian requirements.

Your Canada IMG Checklist

Use this as the final action slide on the BMS website.

- ☐ Confirm medical school / WDOMS eligibility
- ☐ Create and complete physiciansapply.ca profile
- ☐ Establish identity
- ☐ Submit source verification for required credential(s)
- ☐ Prepare for and pass MCCQE Part I
- ☐ Prepare for and pass NAC Examination
- ☐ Check current provincial + program eligibility
- ☐ Prepare CaRMS application + supporting documents
- ☐ Apply strategically to eligible programs
- ☐ Prepare for interviews
- ☐ Submit rank-order list
- ☐ Monitor Match Day + second iteration if needed

FROM MEDICAL DEGREE → TO A CANADIAN RESIDENCY

Official Sources to Check Before You Apply

Medical Council of Canada (MCC)

physiciansapply.ca

MCCQE Part I

NAC Examination

Source verification

Current examination fees + policies

CaRMS

R-1 Match eligibility

Provincial criteria

Program descriptions

Application fees

Match calendar + Match Day

Second iteration / post-match information

BMS principle: use this guide to understand the pathway, then verify every current requirement on the official source before applying.